



impress the client. I loved the data stream! And so did, I imagine, thousands of students and researchers the world over, who no longer had to actually 'research' or truly understand a topic, to write a paper...

Too late! Here she comes...

A soft knock. I hurried to the door, smoothing my shirt and adjusting my tie. I opened the door and there she stood-radiant! She brushed past me and stepped into my office without invitation. Ah! The luxuries of youth! This part was crucial. Everything depended on the next 30 seconds; research was conclusive on the matter. I calmed myself, brushed my right palm lightly against my pants to dry off the sweat as I offered it for a handshake, "Hi, welcome to Bell service center 007. My rep ID is 711. How may I be of service?" Smooth delivery, textbook perfect!

Instead of a friendly smile, as was the predicted result, the woman's lips (full and kissable as they were) turned to frown. DOOM! Sweet, Bountiful G, where did I go wrong?! She then reached for her breast pocket and pulled out something flat and rectangular. It was a visiting card. How quaint! She must be really rich. I suppressed an urge to grin.

The card identified her as Miss Ekta Kaput, producer of the hit show *Kyu ki Al bhi kabhi BAI thi* my eyes swam in tears. I was in the presence of a celebrity! My social matrix will surely gain a few levels thanks to this, but how did I miss this detail from my feeds. No time for that... "How may I be of service Miss...", "...Drop the script", she said plainly and helped herself to a seat, casually playing with her long, silky, and surely pleasantly-smelling hair. Sigh.

I slapped her card on to my table and the table greedily scanned and assimilated her contact details, synching it with my online data repository for anytime / anyplace access. I slowly descended into my chair, maintaining an air of dignity and hoping that this divine integration of curves would notice and appreciate the Bach... "Turn that insipid noise off!" Ah. The thought to strangle her lived and died as briefly as a particle-antiparticle pair in quantum space. If jobs weren't so hard to come by, and even harder to keep, in this ever-implosioning global market—I would have told this... thing... just what I thought of the mental-spam that masqueraded as her show.

No one insults Bach!

"What do you want?" I asked instead, through clenched teeth.

"I have a problem..." I noticed her slightly yellow teeth for the first time; disgusting creature—"...my search queries indicate that you are the only one old enough to be able to help me." Did she just... "I recently bought..." ...Call me old! Why, that little... "It is a gift for..." She had such awkward cheekbones "...Ebay..." And I think I saw the ghost of a moustache. Eww. "... It seems broken. I want it fixed by New Year's..."

I nodded, not really listening to her babble. She sat with a blank expression. I stared back. Silence stretched. Old, it seems...

"So?"

"What?"

"You coming?"

"Sorry?"

"TO FIX THE MACHINE"

"Ah, yes"

I pushed back on the chair, slapped its side to release my comm and twirling it between my fingers, I holstered it on to the Velcro patch on my right thigh as I stood up. It was Clint Eastwood cool—a move that any Bach-loving lady would have melted at the sight of. But not this wicked witch. No sir.

Just then, a thought struck me: this could be potentially dangerous for me and my career. She had mentioned search queries just before wrongly categorising me as old; a query could spell trouble. You see, I, err, have indulged in information engineering in my recent past. Everyone does it! It's just a little white lie and the only way to maintain a decent standing in the social matrix. It's like lying about your weight or your age, so what if I had falsified professional information comprising my online avatar? I could be out of a job, that's what-in jail for a few months, and fined to boot—that's what! I could be in trouble. It all hinged on my ability to be able to repair this machine of hers. If it was... no, it couldn't.

Those things were ancient beyond age.

I began to sweat.

We stepped out of my office and into her car. Her driver drove us home while she wordlessly put on a VR band and logged into another world. The WHEEE VR unit is not "virtual reality" as defined by sci-fi flicks of old, although it intentionally borrows its design from a popular movie. The WHEEE is merely a portable game console which projects an MMORPG in front of the player's eyes. Player movement is controlled by motion sensing RFID chips. Judging by the level display on her helmet, the Bach-hater here had been playing this game for quite some time. No wonder she was so fat and ungainly!

Before long, we reached her place. I was too pissed to be impressed by her opulent bungalow and its verdant grounds.

You could call it a home, if you had no taste.

She led me inside, without a word. We took an elevator to the sixth floor, without a word. It opened to a thickly-carpeted corridor which ended in a red door. We walked towards the door and she stopped inches from it—"this is the room where I keep it. I want it fixed." I looked into her eyes and saw equal parts trepidation and frustration. She seemed so vulnerable, so huggable; maybe I had judged her too harshly.

She opened the door to a Celine Dion song—my heart will go ooooooon. The bungalow suddenly seemed an abomination—a twisted Taj erected as a monument to bad taste. Maybe I ought to burn this place down.

"Please," her eyes implored, "fix it". I surveyed the room, tried to drown out the music by mentally reciting Pi to its 100th decimal place. The machine sat in the middle of the room, with wires sprouting from its body and snaking every which way. It was a computer! An old model too, judging

by the metal decay and its cathode ray display. Nothing seemed wrong to my trained eyes.

"What's wrong with it?"

"WHAT DO YOU MEAN WHAT'S WRONG? CAN'T YOU SEE THAT IT'S BROKEN AND STUCK?"

I slowly turned, taking in each element of the room. I still couldn't... WAIT A MINUTE! I had seen its kind before. As a kid I had spent a healthy percentage of my life staring at them. Could this really be her problem? "I don't know what's wrong", she interrupted: "Sometimes it says 30 minutes remaining, sometimes it says six minutes remaining, and then it jumps back up to 30! 30 MINUTES REMAINING FOR WHAT?!"

I nodded sagely. It was a progress bar. This one was indicating some sort of installation process. This half-brain, tasteless client of mine was obviously too young to have ever seen one.

In 2020, progress bars have given way to progress—software was no longer installed. Indeed, personal computers were an archaic concept. Software was everywhere and immediately available on the massive data-grid. The personal computer had broken up into a hundred different network-aware appliances—be it communicators, data-walls, furniture, or one's clothing! To a creature of this age, a progress bar would appear alien. This was her problem? THIS? I wanted to break into laughter and rub her smug face into her lack of knowledge, but isn't it written—"Verily! Your ignorance is my job security".

I put on my best tech-support face, dropped my voice to the softest possible timbre "this is indeed grave. Please leave this room immediately". She began to protest but I silenced her with my tech-support eyes "I am a veteran of the 2015 Data Wars, do as I say and without question," her eyes shone with awe at this lie—a necessary fabrication to garner more hits and pings. "How long?" I looked at the progress bar—it said 24 minutes, I asked her to leave for an hour. Should be time enough. "But will you..." "Yes." She hugged me then, out of relief. God, she smelled great. "Thank you", she said and flowed out of the door. Beautiful!

I closed the door gently, picked up a packet of chips from a nearby counter and plopped myself onto a comfy sofa. I planned to do absolutely nothing for the next hour. *My heart will go on* gave way to *Nothing's gonna change my love for you*.

I looked at the progress bar and couldn't help but laugh. ■

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